theory of international relations takes the Westphalian state as its basic unit – an independent political entity with sovereignty over its territory and domestic affairs. But this became the norm only after the mid-seventeenth century, when the more nebulous and shifting frontiers of the past began congealing into rigid national boundaries. In an earlier age, successive empires reinforced the multiple networks binding the Indian subcontinent together. Invaders, migrants and traders soon became absorbed in these networks, enriching them and being enriched in return.

This closely interconnected entity is fragmented today, with the subcontinent divided into several sovereign, independent states, India being by far its largest and most powerful entity. This being so, the country's strategic compulsions are still defined by subcontinental concerns that override existing political divisions. It cannot insulate its security from developments within its neighbouring countries. Jawaharlal Nehru was reflecting this reality when he said that the Himalayas constituted India's security perimeter even though some sections of the range fell within the territory of other states such as Nepal. Equally, the country's influence cannot expand beyond the subcontinent without first transcending the political boundaries that divide the subcontinent. India is unable to connect with its extended neighbourhood in the Gulf and Central Asia because its historical contiguity with these geographies is interrupted by Pakistan. In the east, Bangladesh forms a political barrier to India's seamless linking with the South East Asian neighbourhood, although this is gradually being overcome as relations between India and Bangladesh improve.

The situation is complicated by the overlapping ethnicities, kinship and linguistic ties that spill across national boundaries in the subcontinent. People living in West Bengal and Bangladesh share a common language and culture. Tribal communities like the Nagas and the Mizos reside on both sides of the boundary separating India and Myanmar. There are disputes over the divided use of shared natural resources such as rivers and forests.

Since Independence, the persistent challenge for India is the reconciliation of its security interests – which cover the entire subcontinent – with the